

to success. They had raised venture capital from well-regarded investors, had built an awesome team, and were fresh off an impressive debut at one of Silicon Valley's famous startup competitions.

They were extremely process-oriented and disciplined. Their product development followed a rigorous version of the agile development methodology known as Extreme Programming (described below), thanks to their partnership with a San Francisco-based company called Pivotal Labs. Their early product was hailed by the press as a breakthrough.

There was only one problem: they were not seeing sufficient growth in the use of the product by customers. Grockit is an excellent case study because its problems were not a matter of failure of execution or discipline.

Following standard agile practice, Grockit's work proceeded in a series of sprints, or one-month iteration cycles. For each sprint, Farb would prioritize the work to be done that month by writing a series of user stories, a technique taken from agile development. Instead of writing a specification for a new feature that described it in technical terms, Farb would write a story that described the feature from the point of view of the customer. That story helped keep the engineers focused on the customer's perspective throughout the development process.

Each feature was expressed in plain language in terms everyone could understand whether they had a technical background or not. Again following standard agile practice, Farb was free to reprioritize these stories at any time. As he learned more about what customers wanted, he could move things around in the product backlog, the queue of stories yet to be built. The only limit on this ability to change directions was that he could not interrupt any task that was in progress. Fortunately, the stories were written in such a way that the batch size of work (which I'll discuss in more detail in [Chapter 9](#)) was only a day or two.

This system is called agile development for a good reason: teams that employ it are able to change direction quickly, stay light on their feet, and be highly responsive to changes in the business